



Proprietary Solutions Can't Milk Money From These Cooperatives!

The dairy cooperative societies in Kerala are gradually switching to open source in an attempt to cut costs and stay secure.

While people are still contemplating whether to use open source in their mission-critical operations, the Kerala Dairy Cooperative Societies (DCS) has set an example by using open source in its day-to-day activities, to cut costs.

In cooperative societies, a group of dairy farmers come together and are assisted by the government to set up a society. Each district has an average of 100 societies, which could each comprise 200 to 2000 dairy farmers. The farmers bring their produce to the societies, where it is measured in terms of quantity and quality, and this data is recorded on a daily basis. Earlier, their process involved manually entering data into registers, ledgers, schedules and forms. This caused a lot of difficulty in verifying and tracking the status of each activity, and settling accounts with dairy farmers and customers.

The initial exercise, prior to adopting open source, included discussions with the dairy societies to identify their complete requirements and problems. Their main need was automation of office procedures like data entry and the generation of reports.

A computerised information system was developed with the help of National Informatics Centre (NIC) in 2001. Called Lypsaa, it was developed on a Microsoft platform and used Visual Basic for development, Crystal Reports to generate reports, and the Windows 98 operating system. "Though this introduced transparency into the system, proprietary solutions meant a high cost in the form of licence fees for at least 70 systems and servers," shares Khalid C, solutions architect of Lypsaa and a freelance consultant. Moreover, Microsoft stopped supporting some of the software after they launched